

Shakespeare

Beginner Track



Shakespeare: Beginner Track

GRADE(S): 4-8



About the Course

Lessons for Grade 4 and/or those new to Shakespeare who would like a gentle on-ramp to the bard. Lessons cover *A Midsummer Night's Dream* over two terms.



Placement & Combining Tips

Older students can jump into any term of the regular Shakespeare lessons after finishing these, or just read this play and take off one term.



Scheduling

GRADE	SCHEDULE INFO.	BOOKS
4-8	Shakespeare: Beginner Track 1 time/week 30 min	<i>A Midsummer Night's Dream</i> <i>A Midsummer Night's Dream</i> (Audio recording)

Sample Weekly View

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5
Shakespeare: Beginner Track				
		Shakespeare: Beginner Track		



Planning & Prep

Permission to print for non-commercial use. See Alveary group use policy to use lessons in a group context.

LINKS: Click text or scan the QR code in the top corner of the lesson plan pages to view online resources associated with the lessons.

Responsibility for previewing all links rests with the teacher. All links were checked at the time of publication; however, websites change frequently and may contain objectionable content. Please report broken links by contacting us through our website.

Shakespeare: Beginner Track

☐ You may want to read "Shakespeare and a Christian Worldview" which is Ch.9 in the book, *Echoes of Eden – Reflections on Christianity, Literature, and the Arts* by Jerram Barrs. This is an excellent overview of why Shakespeare is important for everyone to know, including Christians.

NOTE on VERSIONS

Students should have an unabridged copy, such as the ones linked in the program, not a modern language edition. The language complexity gets easier to understand with practice. (Note: Shakespeare's work does often contain bawdy jokes or off-color content that will go over the heads of students if left in its original form; a modern language version will lay it all right out there in plain modern English.) We like the Folger editions because they are inexpensive, the lines are numbered (making it easy to find your place), and they contain good notes. These are available on the Folger website as free PDFs as well, though the notes are omitted.

NOTE on CONTENT

Teachers are sometimes wary of reading Shakespeare with their students because the plays contain material that they would deem inappropriate. The Alveary generally follows Mason's programs for younger students. However, that does not mean that your student will never encounter anything unsavory. Our best advice is to read in such a way that these things are moved over quickly, without added attention being drawn to them. Mason assures us that Shakespeare provides students with rich language and character lessons that are unparalleled.



Books & Resources

For book rationales and purchase options, click the Book List link or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Book List Details](#)

Shakespeare: Beginner Track



A Midsummer Night's Dream



A Midsummer Night's Dream (Audio recording)



Supplies

For supply list details and basic supplies helpful to have on hand, click the links or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Basic Supplies](#)

∞ [View Supply List Details](#)

Shakespeare: Beginner Track



A Midsummer Night's Dream Black & White Puppets



A Midsummer Night's Dream Painted Puppets



Quick Links

Shakespeare: Beginner Track

- ∞ [Coloring Puppets](#)
- ∞ [Painted Puppets](#)
- ∞ [Relational Methods, Sec. 9: How to Teach Shakespeare](#)
- ∞ [Appendix: Ideas for Students New to Shakespeare](#)

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Shakespeare: Beginner Track

How To Teach



Prepare

- Read through the lesson and gather any materials or find any necessary links.
- If you have not already read the book, you may want to read the selected pages in advance, especially for Shakespeare lessons. It is helpful to read the play or a preview of it beforehand.
- Choose which books to have students start reading independently (General Literature selections are especially good for independent work).



Recap

- Connect back to the previous lesson. Ask students to give a summary of what they remember and/or predict what might come next. (Full narration is not necessary.)
- If students have difficulty recalling, teachers might try showing them an illustration, sharing something that the teacher remembers, or prompting them with the first sentence of the last reading. This will often refresh their memory enough to allow them to recall.
- If students still cannot recall anything from the last reading, then teachers might consider continuing anyway (with a shorter reading and/or using a combination of visual and audio support this time) or repeating the last lesson, depending on the reading and the nature of the book.



Introduce

- Use a picture, map, or engaging question to pique the student's interest in the day's lesson.
- If necessary, you may talk about one or two unfamiliar words that will be crucial to understanding.



Read

- Read the day's passage aloud or have students read independently. For Shakespeare, it is highly recommended that each student have their own copy of the play and that you read it aloud together or read along and underline/make notes while listening to the audio recording.
- Use supportive strategies and educational tools to reduce frustration and better engage the mind, as appropriate. These could include, but are not limited to, the use of eBooks, pictures, audio, read-aloud, buddy reading, colored reading strips, etc.
- Some students may benefit from having a notebook or piece of scrap paper available to externalize ideas by drawing, recording names, or making symbolic 'squiggle' notes.
- Students who have a difficult time sitting still or listening may benefit from: a fidget of their choice, such as a piece of putty or clay or an afghan; flexible positioning, such as a wobble seat or inverted sitting; or sensory modulation, such as a weighted vest or blanket or adjustment of light, temperature, or sound.



Narrate

- Have students retell the passage orally or in writing. If writing, encourage students to use the full remaining lesson time and include as much detail as they can remember. For Shakespeare or challenging books, it may be helpful to narrate more frequently and/or use props.
- Alternatively, learners may use words, pictures, legos, dolls, etc. to process and convey ideas in the

manner most natural to them.

- Students who used paper or a notebook to externalize may refer to these for support. Other students who need external support may benefit from looking at a map or picture from the book while narrating.
- Students who tend to use the same type of narration all the time, can be encouraged to try another form of narration by first doing it together through play or discussion.
- Teachers may take turns to model.
- Narration is a complex skill that requires the coordination of several parts of the brain. If a student struggles to narrate in general, with a specific subject or book, or on one day but not others, then this is an opportunity to learn. Observe when they struggle with this or any other activity today; notice facial expressions and body language; listen to what they tell about why it is hard or how they feel about it. Take note of these observations for later, tell them that you see how hard they are working, and then offer whatever support they need to end on a positive note or take a break for the day, if necessary.



Discuss

- Give the student an opportunity to share thoughts on the lesson and any connections made.
- To stimulate discussion, you could ask them what they thought about the passage or ask an open-ended question.

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[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

WEEK 1 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 1

Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream, Character Props, Cover sheet,

PREP:

Choose which character props you will use. There are two options. These are listed in the Supply List and in Quick Links.

→ PRINT

Print out a cover sheet for students to keep in their Citizenship notebook or any place they wish. You may also want to print out the lines that will be read aloud during several lessons.

∞ Link: Midsummer Night's Dream Cover Sheet

∞ PDF Link: Lines from Midsummer Night's Dream

→ INTRO

1. William Shakespeare is considered the greatest writer in the English language. He lived from 1564-1616. He is known as the Bard of Avon since he was born in the town Stratford-upon-Avon in England. He wrote around 38 plays as well as many poems. Let's watch this video about his life.

∞ Video: The Life and Times of William Shakespeare

2. We are going to read the play Midsummer Night's Dream. Look at this cover page.

∞ Link: Midsummer Night's Dream Cover Sheet

What does the title tell you about the play? What sorts of things do you think you will read about? In the video, we heard that Shakespeare wrote three kinds of plays—tragedy, comedy and history. Which one do you think this is?

3. We are going to practice some lines from the play. We can read it aloud together or you can listen to me first. Let's see what some of these words mean: bank—a mound of grass; blow—burst into flower

The speaker is describing an area where Titania the fairy lives where the flowers are blooming and blowing in the breeze. There is a special flower that can put a spell on people. We will find out about that later. Now let's read it again.

∞ PDF Link: Lines from Midsummer Night's Dream (Passage 1)

→ READ

Read about half of the retelling and save half for next time. As you read the retelling you may want to have your student have the character props in front of them to go along with the story.

∞ Link: Beautiful Stories from Shakespeare

Beginning - "or a busy ape."

→ NARRATE

Students can narrate using their character props if desired.

★ TEACHER NOTE

For the first two weeks you will read a retelling of the play so students are familiar with the story. We are linking Edith Nesbit's retelling but you can also read Lamb's Tales from Shakespeare or another retelling you may have.

WEEK 2 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 2

Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream

→ RECAP

What did we read last time?

→ PRACTICE

Let's read aloud the lines from Passage 1.

∞ PDF Link: Lines from Midsummer Night's Dream



Term 1

→ INTRO

Where did people watch Shakespeare's plays when they were first written? Watch this video to learn more about the Globe Theatre.

∞ Video Link: The Globe Theatre

→ READ

We will finish the retelling today. As you read the retelling you may want to have your student have the character props in front of them to go along with the story.

∞ Link: Beautiful Stories from Shakespeare

"While Puck was gone" - end

→ NARRATE

Students can narrate using their character props if desired.

WEEK 3 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 3

📄 Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream, Student World Atlas

PREP:

1. Print out a list of characters.

∞ PDF Link: List of Characters

2. Print out the narration sheets. Students will use these after each lesson to add a picture or write some key words.

∞ PDF Link: Narration sheets

→ PRACTICE

Let's read aloud the lines from Passage 1. (Links are in lessons 1 or 2)

→ INTRO

Let's look at the list of characters. (As an option, you can watch this video that describes the characters. Please preview.)

∞ Video Link: Overview of Characters

→ LOCATE

📄 Map Resource: Student World Atlas. p.30-31

Find Greece on the World Map. What continent is it part of?

Now let's zoom in closer and look at a map of Greece. Find Athens. That is where this play takes place. What are the names of other cities in Greece? What body of water surrounds Greece?

∞ Map Link: Map of Greece

→ READ

In place of reading, you may also follow along with Scene 1 in your book, while listening to the free Arkangel audio on the Folger website (linked below). First read students the summary of the scene on p.6.

Act 1: Scene 1 p.7-15 Beginning of Scene - "we follow you."

∞ Link: Arkangel Scene 1 (recording at bottom of page)

(Audio Timemarker: Beginning - 7:36)

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

Students can narrate using the character props.

- The anticipation of what event begins the play?
- What complaint does Egeus bring to Theseus?

★ TEACHER TIP

You may want to preview vocabulary on the left hand side in the Folger edition and share a few words with your students. (This is optional.)

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[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

WEEK 4 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 4

Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream

→ PRACTICE

Let's read aloud the lines from Passage 1.

∞ PDF Link: Lines from Midsummer Night's Dream

→ READ

In place of reading, you may also follow along with Scene 1 in your book, while listening to the free Arkangel audio on the Folger website (linked below).

Act 1: Scene 1

p.15-23 "How now, my love?" - End of scene

∞ Link: Arkangel Scene 1 (audio recording at bottom of page. Start at time marker 7:36).

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

Students can narrate back using the character props.

- How do the young lovers respond?

→ ACTIVITY

Have students fill out narration sheet for Act 1, Scene 1

WEEK 5 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 5

Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream

PREP: Read the story of Pyramus and Thisbe and share your narration with the student. (optional)

∞ Link: The Love Story of Pyramus and Thisbe

→ RECAP

What did we read last time?

→ PRACTICE

Let's read aloud the lines from Passage 1.

∞ PDF Link: Lines from Midsummer Night's Dream

→ INTRO

Read the summary of the scene on p.24 to your students.

→ READ

Act 1: Scene 2 p.25-31

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

Students can narrate using their character props if desired.

- Who are the "rude mechanicals"?

Tell about their plans for a play.

→ ACTIVITY

Have students fill out narration sheet for Act 1, Scene 2

★ TEACHER TIP: Refer to the Character Chart as you are reading.

WEEK 6 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 6

Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream

PREP: You may want to preview vocabulary on the left hand side in the Folger edition and share a few words with your students. (This is optional.) We have made some suggestions every so often in the right-hand column.

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Term 1

→ RECAP

What did we read last time?

→ PRACTICE

Let's read aloud the lines from Passage 1.

∞ PDF Link: Lines from Midsummer Night's Dream

→ INTRO

Read the summary of the scene on p.34 to your students.

→ READ

Act 2: Scene 1

p.35-39 Beginning of scene - "that he were gone!"

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

Students can narrate using their character props if desired.

WEEK 7 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 7

📄 Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream

PREP: You may want to preview vocabulary on the left hand side in the Folger edition and share a few words with your students. (This is optional.) We have made some suggestions every so often in the right-hand column.

→ PRACTICE

Let's read aloud the lines from Passage 1.

∞ PDF Link: Lines from Midsummer Night's Dream

→ READ

Act 2: Scene 1

p.39-47 "Ill met by" - "overhear their conference."

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

Students can narrate using their character props if desired.

WEEK 8 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 8

📄 Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream

PREP: You may want to preview vocabulary on the left hand side in the Folger edition and share a few words with your students. (This is optional.) We have made some suggestions every so often in the right-hand column.

→ PRACTICE

Let's read aloud the lines from Passage 1.

∞ PDF Link: Lines from Midsummer Night's Dream

→ READ,

Act 2: Scene 1

p.47-53 "I love thee" - End of scene

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

Students can narrate using their character props if desired.

- Why are Oberon and Titania fighting?

→ ACTIVITY

Have students fill out narration sheet for Act 2, Scene 1

★ TEACHER TIP: Refer to the Character Chart as you are reading.

Shakespeare: Beginner Track

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

WEEK 9 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 9

Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream

PREP: You may want to preview vocabulary on the left hand side in the Folger edition and share a few words with your students. (This is optional.) We have made some suggestions every so often in the right-hand column.

→ RECAP

What did we read last time?

→ PRACTICE

Let's read aloud the lines from Passage 1.

∞ PDF Link: Lines from Midsummer Night's Dream

→ INTRO

Read the introduction to the scene on p.52 aloud to your students.

→ READ

Act 2: Scene 2

p.53-61 Beginning of the scene - "alone will go."

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

Students can narrate using their character props if desired.

- Who do you think is more responsible for the chaos and confusion that unfolds in the wood, Oberon or Puck?

WEEK 10 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 10

Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream

PREP: Preview Vocabulary: almanac

→ RECAP

What did we read last time?

→ PRACTICE

We have a new passage we will read today. What are mortals? Let's read aloud the lines from Passage 2.

∞ PDF Link: Lines from Midsummer Night's Dream

→ INTRO

Read the introduction to the scene on p.68 aloud to your students. (You can wait to read the summary until you finish Act 2, Scene 2.)

→ READ

Act 2: Scene 2-Act 3: Scene 1

p.61-73 "O, I am" - "played here."

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

Students can narrate using their character props if desired.

- What problems do Bottom and the others find with the play?

→ ACTIVITY

Have students fill out narration sheet for Act 2 Scene 2

• EXTRA HELPING

View a current almanac; discuss how it is used and add it to your daily routine.

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Term 1

WEEK 11 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 11

Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream

→ RECAP

What did we read last time?

→ PRACTICE

Let's read aloud the lines from Passage 2.

∞ PDF Link: Lines from Midsummer Night's Dream

→ INTRO

1. Read the introduction to the scene p.68 aloud to your students.

2. What do you think will happen when Titania wakes up and was given the love potion? Let's watch a production of that part of the scene.

∞ Video Link: Titania Wakes Up

→ READ

Act 3: Scene 1

p.75-81 "Must I speak" - End of scene

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

Students can narrate using their character props if desired.

- How do they intend to solve those problems and meet what they consider to be the expectations of their audience?

→ ACTIVITY

Have students fill out narration sheet for Act 3: Scene 1

WEEK 12 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 12

Exam Week

→ EXAMS

Answer question(s) related to course.

Questions will come from:

A Midsummer Night's Dream

Shakespeare: Beginner Track

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 2

WEEK 1 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 13

Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream

→ RECAP

What did we read last time?

→ PRACTICE

Let's read aloud the lines from Passage 2.

∞ PDF Link: Lines from Midsummer Night's Dream

→ INTRO

Read the introduction to the scene p.82 aloud to your students.

→ READ

Act 3: Scene 2

p.83-91 Beginning of scene - "befall prepost'rously."

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

Students can narrate using their character props if desired.

WEEK 2 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 14

Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream

→ RECAP

What did we read last time?

→ PRACTICE

Let's read aloud the lines from Passage 2.

∞ PDF Link: Lines from Midsummer Night's Dream

→ READ,

Act 3: Scene 2

p.91-101 "Why should you" - "Quick, come."

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

Students can narrate using their character props if desired.

- Why does Helena think everyone is ganging up on her?

★ TEACHER NOTE

You may want to preview vocabulary on the left hand side in the Folger edition and share a few words with your students. (This is optional.)

WEEK 3 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 15

Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream

→ RECAP

What did we read last time?

→ READ

Act 3: Scene 2

p.101-107 "Lysander, whereto" - "know not what to say."

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

Students can narrate using their character props if desired.

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Term 2

WEEK 4 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 16

Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream

→ RECAP

What did we read last time?

→ READ,

Act 3: Scene 2

p.107-117 "This is thy" - End of scene.

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

Students can narrate using their character props if desired.

- What two things does Puck do, on Oberon's orders, to keep Demetrius and Lysander from fighting?
- How does he plan to put everything right again?

→ ACTIVITY

Have students fill out narration sheet for Act 3: Scene 2

WEEK 5 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 17

Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream

→ RECAP

What did we read last time?

→ INTRO

Read the introduction to the scene p.120 aloud to your students.

→ READ,

Act 4: Scene 1

p.121-127 Beginning of scene -"on the ground."

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

Students can narrate using their character props if desired.

WEEK 6 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 18

Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream

→ RECAP

What did we read last time?

→ INTRO

Read the introductions to each scene p.136 aloud to your students before you begin each scene.

→ READ

Act 4: Scene 1

p.129-137 Go, one of you," - End of scene

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

Students can narrate using their character props if desired.

- What is Bottom's dream about?
- See note on p.134 in Folger for lines 220-226. What is the significance of having Bottom echo St. Paul?

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Term 2

→ ACTIVITY

Have students fill out narration sheet for Act 4 Scene 1

WEEK 7 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 19

Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream

→ RECAP

What did we read last time?

→ READ

Act 4: Scene 2-Act 5: Scene 1

p.137-149 Beginning of scene - "places, ladies."

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

Students can narrate using their character props if desired.

- Why does Theseus choose the rude mechanicals' (craftsmen's) play to be performed at the wedding celebration?

→ ACTIVITY

Have students fill out narration sheet for Act 4: Scene 2

WEEK 8 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 20

Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream

→ RECAP

What did we read last time?

→ READ

Act 5: Scene 1

p.149-157 "I love not" - "away doth go."

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

Students can narrate using their character props if desired.

WEEK 9 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 21

Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream

→ RECAP

What did we read last time?

→ READ

Act 5: Scene 1

p.157-165 "Now is the" - "die, die, die."

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

Students can narrate using their character props if desired.

WEEK 10 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 22

Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream

→ LISTEN

Felix Mendelssohn was a German composer who lived in the 1800's. He was inspired by this play to write several pieces of music called Incidental Music. We will listen to the most famous piece. Does this sound familiar? What do you think it might be

★ TEACHER NOTE

Look ahead to next week's lesson to decide how you wish to structure the time from the options given.

• EXTRA HELPING

You may want to watch

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Term 2

called? (Wedding March) This song is used in many weddings as a procession after the bride and groom are married. (You can listen to the youtube or spotify link.)

∞ Link: Wedding March (YouTube)

∞ Link: Wedding March (Spotify)

→ READ

Act 5: Scene 1

p.165-173 "No die," - End of scene

→ NARRATE & DISCUSS

Students can narrate using their character props if desired.

→ ACTIVITY

Have students fill out narration sheet for Act 5: Scene 1

scenes or the whole play from this animated adaptation of A Midsummer Night's Dream.

∞ Link: Animated version

WEEK 11 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 23

📄 Materials: A Midsummer Night's Dream or 30-minute Shakespeare

PREP: This is a good week to wrap up the play with one of these suggestions:

→ ACTIVITY

Watch a recorded performance or act out the play or a scene.

1. Watch selected scenes from a recorded production of the play. We have suggestions in Extra Helpings. (Make sure to preview.)

2. Act out a scene of the play. (We recommend Act V.)

3. Act out an abridged version such as The 30-minute Shakespeare.

∞ Link to purchase: 30-minute Shakespeare from website (PDF or paperback)

∞ Link to purchase: 30-minute Shakespeare from Amazon (Kindle or paperback)

• EXTRA HELPING

If you want to put on a play or dress-up, you can find some costume ideas on this website.

∞ Link: Costume Ideas

WEEK 12 30m Shakespeare: Beginner Track - Lesson 24

Exam Week

→ EXAMS

Answer question(s) related to course.

Questions will come from:

A Midsummer Night's Dream

Shakespeare: Beginner Track

Examination

Term 1

- GRADES 4-8 - A Midsummer Night's Dream: Describe a scene with your favorite character.

Term 2

- GRADES 4-8 - A Midsummer Night's Dream: Describe a scene that takes place in the woods.
- GRADES 7-8 - A Midsummer Night's Dream: Tell how Puck changed throughout the play.